

Opinion of the Court.

would be bad on general demurrer; and thereupon judgment was rendered for the defendant on the pleadings alone.

The complaint, upon examination, shows the allegation of an indebtedness from the defendant to the plaintiff, for money unlawfully demanded, exacted and received by the defendant under color of law, and paid by the plaintiff in ignorance of its rights, in consequence of representations made by the defendant, and under protest; and this indebtedness is alleged as the consideration of an implied promise to repay the same. This statement, it is quite true, is general and vague. It does not allege with particularity the laws under color of which the exactions were made, nor the circumstances attending the payment. But it is sufficient; for an actual indebtedness is alleged, and there is nothing in the complaint to contradict the fact, or to demonstrate its impossibility as matter of law. And, although the complaint states that the money was exacted "under color of certain laws in the State of New York concerning passengers in vessels coming to the State of New York, and concerning the powers and duties of Commissioners of Emigration, and for the regulation of marine hospitals," this does not necessarily identify the moneys alleged to have been thus exacted and paid with the "head moneys," the collection of which it was the professed object of the act of Congress to legalize. If it be said that it is matter of judicial cognizance that there were in New York at the time no other laws, under color of which such exactions and payments could have been made—which we do not admit—nevertheless, it remains, that, consistently with the allegations of the complaint, the moneys paid may have been illegally exacted in violation of the laws under color of which, it is alleged, their payment was demanded and made. And the allegation in the answer, that the moneys sued for are, in fact, the "head moneys" which the act of Congress prohibits the recovery of, does not cure the difficulty, for that may have been the very issue to be tried. Taking the complaint to be true, which is what we are bound to do in the present state of the record, the indebtedness alleged to exist must be admitted to exist in fact, if it is possible to exist in law; and this, we may affirm, even though the act of Congress

Opinion of the Court.

pleaded and adjudged to be a bar, be a valid law ; for it is not apparent on the record that the money sued for was "head money," nor that it was exacted and paid in accordance with the laws of the State. It will certainly not be denied that, if the moneys sued for were exacted and paid in violation of the laws of New York, under color of which, it is said, they were demanded, and the exaction and payment were made under circumstances authorizing a recovery under the laws of that State, or of the common law in force there, it was not the intention of Congress to interpose a bar to the suit. It is impossible for us on this record to say that this is not such a case.

If, on the other hand, we should assume the plaintiff's case to be within the terms of the statute, we should have to deal with it purely as an hypothesis, and pass upon the constitutionality of an act of Congress as an abstract question. That is not the mode in which this court is accustomed or willing to consider such questions. It has no jurisdiction to pronounce any statute, either of a State or of the United States, void, because irreconcilable with the Constitution, except as it is called upon to adjudge the legal rights of litigants in actual controversies. In the exercise of that jurisdiction, it is bound by two rules, to which it has rigidly adhered, one, never to anticipate a question of constitutional law in advance of the necessity of deciding it; the other never to formulate a rule of constitutional law broader than is required by the precise facts to which it is to be applied. These rules are safe guides to sound judgment. It is the dictate of wisdom to follow them closely and carefully.

In the present case, the main and ultimate question is whether the defendant is legally liable to repay the moneys sued for, and, as incidental to that, whether the act of Congress pleaded as a bar to the action is valid. The solution of these questions depends upon facts not apparent upon the present record. That these may be made to appear there must be a new trial.

For these reasons

The judgment of the Circuit Court is reversed, and the cause remanded, with directions to award a new trial ; and it is so ordered.

Opinion of the Court.

DAVISON & Another v. VON LINGEN & Others.

APPEAL FROM THE CIRCUIT COURT OF THE UNITED STATES FOR
THE DISTRICT OF MARYLAND.

Argued December 12, 1884.—Decided January 5, 1885.

A stipulation in the charter-party of a steamer, that she is "now sailed, or about to sail, from Benizaf, with cargo, for Philadelphia," is a stipulation that she has her cargo on board and is ready to sail.

A charter-party with the above stipulation was made on the 1st of August, in Philadelphia. The steamer was at Benizaf, in Morocco, only three-elevenths loaded, and did not sail for Philadelphia till August 7, and left Gibraltar August 9. Before signing the charter-party, the charterers asked to have in it a guaranty that the steamer would reach Philadelphia in time to load a cargo for Europe in August, but this was refused. They declined to have inserted the words "sailed from, or loading at Benizaf." On learning when the steamer left Gibraltar, they proceeded to look for another vessel. The unloading of the steamer at Philadelphia was completed September 7, but the charterers repudiated the contract: *Held*,

- (1.) The stipulation was a warranty or a condition precedent, and not a mere representation;
- (2.) Time and the situation of the vessel were material and essential parts of the contract;
- (3.) The charterers had a right to repudiate the contract, and to recover from the owners of the steamer the increased cost of employing another vessel.

The facts which make the case are stated in the opinion of the court.

Mr. A. Stirling, Jr., for appellants, submitted on his brief.

Mr. T. Wallis Blakistone (*Mr. John H. Thomas* was with him) for appellees.

MR. JUSTICE BLATCHFORD delivered the opinion of the court.

On the 1st of August, 1879, a charter-party was entered into between the owners of the steamship *Whickham* and the firm of A. Schumacher & Co., composed of George A. Von Lingen, Carl A. Von Lingen, and William G. Atkinson, of which the parts material to this case are as follows: